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Sometimes a Cross is just a Cross: Taking Psychoanalysis to Church

Immanuel Kant's *Critique of Practical Reason* and *Religion within the Boundaries of Mere Reason* deal with a similar problematic. In the former, given that in theoretical reason, he had banished the global concepts of world, self and God to Ideas unavailable to intuition but instead must be explained as arising from the categories of the understanding which renders sensible merely local phenomena, then how can such global concepts return in their proper use in regard to practical reason? Similarly, in the *Religion*, given that the origination of the good maxim can arise neither from our animal nature or our culture, where can we find the possibility of our acting freely to appropriate the moral law in the world? In each of these cases, Kant makes reference to the phenomena/noumena distinction to resolve the dichotomy wherein we must posit the possibility of God's mechanism through nature, though not one amenable to the categories of understanding, as the cause whose production is our moral conversion. Hence we must represent to ourselves the possibility of the highest good, i.e., God, which would make our ends commensurable not only as a species but also with the world. While this may seem unconvincing, the nature of this argument gains in cogency when we examine the dichotomy of phenomena/noumena from the perspective of psychoanalysis. In this essay, it will be argued that the paradoxes of Kant's moral and transcendental faith can be more clearly illumined in

reference to psychoanalytic practice, and that the discoveries there will be relevant for the mission of the ecclesiastical and civil communities in important ways. To begin elucidating this problematic, it will be useful to return to Kant's *Religion* to establish the difference between good and evil in humanity.

At the beginning of the *Religion*, Kant recognizes the proposition “[t]hat “the world lieth in evil” is a complaint as old as history”¹ and references in many religions claims such as that “the Last Day and the destruction of the world are knocking at the door”.² However, he also notices that the “heroic opinion” has been taken up which posits “that the world steadfastly (though hardly noticeably) forges ahead in the very opposite direction, namely from bad to better” and, in reference to humanity as a species, “that at least there is in the human being the predisposition to move in this direction” but he concludes however that such views “have not [been] drawn... from experience, for the history of all times attests far too powerfully against it”.³ In bringing up the question of these global claims of historical teleology, however, it is not Kant's intention to answer either affirmatively or negatively regarding their validity, but to correct the structure of their ground in the relationship between humanity as a species of thinking being, and the world as a place of its dwelling. As Kant states, “Whenever we therefore say, “The human is by nature good,” or, “He is by nature evil,” this only means that he holds within himself a first ground (to us inscrutable) for the adoption of good or evil (unlawful) maxims”⁴ meaning that what is at stake is not what is the nature, in substantial terms, of humanity and the world but, rather, is humanity capable of taking up subjective maxims that are either good or evil. Hence nature (in this sense) is not opposed to freedom since we only refer by nature the

¹ Immanuel Kant, *Religion within the Boundaries of Mere Reason*, 45/6:20

² Ibid.

³ Ibid.

⁴ Ibid., 47/6:22

possibility of humanity's ability to ground their maxim which must be available to them as a species, as he explains in a footnote, "Since the adoption is free, its ground... must not be sought in any incentive of nature, but always again in a maxim".⁵ In this sense, we see a microcosm of the transcendental philosophy at play in the *Religion* since the task is not to identify in ourselves a substance that is relatable to the good (substance) or to be hylomorphically organized as to tend towards goodness (insofar as certain conditions are met) but rather, with freedom as its determining ground, whether humanity can and will (freely) adopt as its determining maxim either the good or evil principle. Nevertheless, Kant reminds us that "to have one or the other disposition by nature as an innate characteristic does not mean here that the disposition has not been earned by the human being who harbors it... rather that it has not been earned in time".⁶ Hence, what Kant is establishing is the freedom to posit the *ontological* character of humanity without such ontology lapsing into dogmatism, but still providing the human the free ground of determining its own maxims and hence being its authors as original predispositions which can either be good or evil. Human beings cannot be composite creatures which are "morally good in some parts, and at the same time evil in others"⁷ but rather since the question is one of humanity's capacities of determining ends, presupposes an original disposition to good which must apply univocally to all of the species. These dispositions can either be good or evil, of which the former will be treated first.

Kant locates three possible determinations under which it can be said that the human being is good by original predisposition: either through our *animality* "as a living being", our *humanity* "as a living and at the same time *rational* being", or through our *personality*, "as a rational and at

⁵ Ibid.

⁶ Ibid., 50/6:26.

⁷ Ibid., 49/6:25.

the same time *responsible* being”.⁸ The first, animality, can be “brought under the general title of physical or merely *mechanical* self-love” including our disposition for “self-preservation”, “propagation of the species, through the sexual drive”, or “community with other human beings, i.e., the social drive” which all have their corresponding vices as well. Of the second disposition, living and rational, can be “brought under the general title of a self-love which is physical and yet *involves comparison* (for which reason is required) or, as he otherwise puts it, that it is “only in comparison with others [that] one judge[s] oneself happy or unhappy”⁹ and hence gives rise to our tendency to be jealous and rivalrous, or secretous with regards to others. According to Kant, these inclinations are how nature promotes “an incentive to culture”.¹⁰ To summarize thus far, if the first were to be the basis of the origination of the good maxim, then this would reduce the origination of the good maxim to merely habit, thus reducing our ontological status to mere animals. However, if it were the second, then, though admitting of our rational, would reduce the origination of the good maxim to merely culture, thus reducing us to mere utility calculating machines in search of happiness. Kant explains, “we find that the *first* does not have reason at its root at all; that the *second* is rooted in a reason which is indeed practical but only as subservient to other incentives; and that the *third* alone is rooted in reason practical of itself”.¹¹ In this sense, Kant identifies the character of the moral law as accountability towards Persons; it is not that we treat others as ends because there is an arbitrary, capricious ruleset that we must abide by but rather because, in our very acting, we necessarily take ourselves to be accountable to the moral law by the fact that our maxim has the predisposition to good arising from its ability to be receptive to the good maxim. It is not sufficient, therefore, for one to think of themselves as a

⁸ Ibid., 50/6:26.

⁹ Ibid., 51/6:27.

¹⁰ Ibid.

¹¹ Ibid., 52/6:28.

mere natural or animal creature, nor is it sufficient to think of oneself as a creature existing in culture or as a societal cog as neither does justice to our status as Persons—that is, responsible for the moral law as the most proper incentive for us to take. Since it must be applied not to any particular individual but to the species as a whole, then all relations between individuals in humanity must have the character of Person *qua* Person relations.

Therefore, the origination of the good maxim must arise from “[t]he predisposition to personality” which is “the susceptibility to respect for the moral law *as of itself a sufficient incentive to the power of choice*” which, though a feeling cannot in itself be considered natural and hence determinative but only serves as “an incentive for the power of choice” which allows us constitute in our maxim the character of the morally good “onto which nothing evil can be grafted”.¹² In this way, Kant preserves an account of our originally good disposition without relying on a determinative substance yet nevertheless not undermining our freedom before the law without reference to our being composite creatures that are in some part and some part evil.

Kant therefore needs to account for where the intelligibility of evil humanity emerges from since we so often fall from the moral law. Whereas we have a predisposition towards the good, Kant claims that we merely have a *propensity* to evil which “can indeed be innate yet *may* be represented as not being such” and can either be *acquired* or merely *brought* upon itself.¹³ Hence, while it is of human nature to have such a propensity to evil, it cannot be said that this is necessary, determining feature of the human being as such. In this way, “moral evil... s only possible as the determination of a free power of choice and this power for its part can be judged good or evil only on the basis of its maxim” and “must reside in the subjective ground of the possibility of the deviation of the maxims from the moral law”.¹⁴ Such propensity comes in three

¹² Ibid.

¹³ Ibid., 52-53/6:29.

¹⁴ Ibid., 53/6:29.

grades, namely, *frailty*, *impurity* and *depravity*. The first is defined by incorporating the good maxim into our determining power of choice such that it is unable to overcome our inclination towards the propensity to evil. The second is defined by incorporating the good maxim, but not as the *sufficient* determining cause of our maxim. The last is defined when the incorporation of the good maxim is made subordinate to other maxims and hence “the mind’s attitude is thereby corrupted at its root... and hence the human being is designated as evil”.¹⁵ Thus, all three gradations of the propensity for evil demonstrate that humanity cannot act without, if imperfectly, incorporating the good maxim as the determining ground of their will. Nevertheless, there is a propensity for evil that renders the action evil by being tainted with other inclinations and hence to act in contradiction to the responsibility towards reason that we contain within ourselves. In this way, when we fail to ground the good maxim as the sole determining ground of our action, then we fail to be persons instead reducing ourselves to some instrumental end of either our own bodies or our culture.

Since we cannot take ourselves, when considered in regard to reason alone, as anything but Persons, then to say that humanity is evil is merely to say “that he is conscious of the moral law and yet has incorporated into his maxim the (occasional) deviation from it”¹⁶ and to say it is by nature means only “that being evil applies to him considered in his species”.¹⁷ Kant draws several *political* conclusions from this recognition. Namely, he recognizes through this propensity to evil the impossibility of encountering “the natural goodliness of human nature” in a “state of nature” such as those populations of non-European descent.¹⁸ Furthermore, we neither transcend such a natural propensity for evil through civilized people, though it is important that

¹⁵ Ibid., 54/6:30.

¹⁶ Ibid., 55/6:32.

¹⁷ Ibid., 56/6:32.

¹⁸ Ibid., 56/6:33.

we do not allow ourselves to be “dragged... into another vice, namely that of misanthropy” from the fact.¹⁹ Such mixed relations of states of either sort, also, cannot be avoided, and thus inevitably lead to the possibility of war even if it is “directly in contradiction to official policy”²⁰ which becomes the basis on which both perpetual peace and the “completed moral improvement of the human race” are derided as both philosophical and theological chiasm respectively.²¹ Nevertheless, despite the permanence of these inherent conditions, it is not ground to rationally posit the pessimistic (or misanthropic) attitude since the propensity to evil cannot be *grounded* in humanity’s “sensuous nature” and “natural inclinations” though giving occasion for its possibility, is not its determining ground but merely the failure to uphold the good maxim as sole determining ground.²² However, despite how deep the propensity of evil in human nature is to be taken, it cannot be said that such a situation is unable to be overcome. Hence Kant concludes that, “so long as the foundation of the maxims of the human being remains impure, [it] cannot be effected through gradual *reform* but must rather be effected through a *revolution* in the disposition of a human being” such that it can be said a “new man can come about only through a kind of rebirth, as it were a new creation”.²³ Such a revolution must be taken as possible insofar as the Person is taken to be free before the moral law, which as discussed above is a necessary presupposition of the origination of the good maxim in humanity. However, this leads us to a discussion regarding the possibility of the world as such a place wherein such revolution is possible, and hence leads us into the *Critique of Practical Reason* wherein such a noumenal will can appear in a phenomenal world.

¹⁹ Ibid., 57/6:34.

²⁰ Ibid.

²¹ Ibid.

²² Ibid.

²³ Ibid., 68/6:48.

Kant himself formulates a version of the problematic when he states, "...how can one *deny* the objective *reality* to the supersensible *use of the categories* in speculation and yet *grant* them this *reality* with respect to the objects of pure practical reason".²⁴ There arises a seeming contradiction wherein the supersensible objects of world, self and God cannot be account for through intuitions, and yet they are granted to at least be capable of reality with respect to the reflective capacity of practical reason, stating, "for this must previously have seemed *inconsistent*, as long as such a practical use is known only by name."²⁵ However, this is a misunderstanding as cognition of the supersensible merely requires that "an *object* belongs to them" not through subsuming the particular to a determination under the categories but "because they are either contained in the necessary determination of the will a priori or else are inseparably connected with the object of its determination".²⁶ What this allows Kant to do is state that, though there are no intuitions of world, self and God that render them intelligible, "practical reason of itself... furnishes reality to a supersensible object of the category of causality, namely to *freedom*... and hence establishes by means of a fact what could there [first Critique] could only be *thought*."²⁷ He elaborates further stating, "*that even the thinking subject is in inner intuition a mere appearance to itself*, gets its full confirmation in the *Critique of Practical Reason*".²⁸ Hence, similar to the *Religion*, where the Person was established as the proper object of respect before the moral law, it is through knowledge of the moral law that the notion of the self is given determinacy. The following passage from Kant helps elucidate this following conundrum:

²⁴ Immanuel Kant, Critique of Practical Reason, 141/5:6.

²⁵ Ibid.

²⁶ Ibid.

²⁷ Ibid.

²⁸ Ibid.

“But something different and quite paradoxical takes the place of this vainly sought deduction of the moral principle, namely that the moral principle, conversely itself serves as the principle of the deduction of an inscrutable faculty which no experience could prove but which speculative reason had to assume as to least possible (in order to find among its cosmological ideas what is unconditioned in its causality, so as not to contradict itself), namely the faculty of freedom, of which the moral law, which itself has no need of justifying grounds, proves not only the possibility but the reality in brings who cognize this law as binding upon them.”²⁹

Hence the moral law bears witness to “the possibility of a supersensible nature”.³⁰ This is because, though natural phenomena are explainable through intuitions determined by the categories of the understanding, such an intuition is not possible for concepts like the world, self and God. Nevertheless, the moral law serves, in its practical use, as their determining ground and, perhaps surprisingly, with real effects in the world, namely that of respect for the Person. Hence, since individuals are capable of providing the determining ground of their maxims *through* the moral law, this bears witness to the reality of a (and *their*) supersensible nature, even if such a nature is opaque to us and not strictly amenable to the forms of intuition. We must represent the world as determined purely through cause and effect but, nevertheless, must postulate the possibility that there are at least some phenomena that cannot be explained through

²⁹ Ibid., 178/5:48.

³⁰ Ibid.

such means. This becomes a central topic in the *Critique of the Power of Judgment* in the representation of the antinomy of teleological judgment.³¹ However, there, just as in the first and second Critiques, Kant is always careful to distinguish between phenomena and noumena and posits that there is no such unification of the two principles possible since such unification would lead to dogmatism or enthusiasm. In regards to the feeling of respect, Kant says the following:

“And now the law of duty, through the positive worth that observance of it lets us feel, finds easier access through the *respect for ourselves* in the consciousness of our freedom. When this is well established, when a human being dreads nothing more than to find, on self-examination, that he is worthless and contemptible in his own eyes, then every good moral disposition can be grafted onto it, because this is the best, and indeed the sole, guard to prevent ignoble and corrupting impulses from breaking into the mind.”³²

It is through the feeling of guilt—i.e., of having failed the moral law, that Kant believes one can start to cultivate a sense of respect, both in their own Person, as well as in the Person of others. Nevertheless, such guilt cannot be seen as determining our maxim before the moral law, and thus lapsing us back into our animality as the basis for the moral law, but merely as a propaedeutic which would allow for the moral transformation through the subject in which they can return to a proper respect for the moral law, both in themselves and in others.

³¹ Immanuel Kant, *Critique of the Power of Judgment*, 259/5:388.

³² Immanuel Kant, *Critique of Practical Reason*, 269/5:161.

Hence freedom can be posited as having causality precisely through the inner intuition of the subject, through which arises a feeling of respect. This respect for the Person cannot merely be in reference to the instrumentality of culture or animality, as Kant says, “So distinctly and sharply drawn are the boundaries of morality and self-love that even the most common eye cannot fail to distinguish whether something belongs to the one or the other.”³³ Hence, though “[t]he principle of happiness can indeed furnish maxims” it would not “be fit for laws of the will, even if *universal* happiness were made the object”.³⁴ To reiterate, this would again to reduce the moral law to animality, and hence would be improper for the determination of the will which, taken in itself, determines us as Persons. Though it would be therefore basic to humanity to strive for such happiness, it is nevertheless only a propaedeutic for the dignity demanded by the law and afforded to each individual. Kant elaborates stating, “The maxim of self-love (prudence) merely *advises*; the law of morality *commands*. But there is a great difference between that which we are *advised* to do and that to which we are *obligated*.”³⁵ This obligation, therefore, cannot be merely a heteronomous impulse regarding one’s phenomenal animality but must be regarded as evidence for the possibility of the supersensible determination of the will such that “[a]ppraising what is to be done in accordance with it must, therefore, not be so difficult that the most common and unpracticed understanding should not know how to go about it, even without worldly prudence.”³⁶ Hence the moral law must be treated as a species-wide command univocally applicable to each individual and not merely to the learned and undifferentiated in regards to class, status, sex, or race. Kant states, “[t]herefore the moral law is even subjectively a ground of respect.”³⁷

³³ Ibid., 169/5:36.

³⁴ Ibid.

³⁵ Ibid., 169/5:37.

³⁶ Ibid., 169/5:37.

³⁷ Ibid., 200/5:75.

The question of the drives (Kant's term being inclinations) of practical reason and the feeling of respect is immediately applicable to the nature of psychoanalysis. Alenka Zupančič argues "that the Kantian notion of respect might be situated in the same register as the psychoanalytic (or, rather, Lacanian) notion of anxiety".³⁸ She notes that, even if Kant cannot prove the existence of the moral law as determining ground for the will for sensible intuition, that "we can at least prove that it must exist—that it actually *happens* that the moral law directly determines the will" because of "the *effect* it produces, and it is this effect that Kant conceives of in terms of (the feeling of) respect".³⁹ Hence, Zupančič notices that Kant's solution to the reality of the moral law, as discussed above, is not to find a determining ground for the moral law or freedom in the categories of the understanding but merely to locate in the effects of the law (i.e. the feeling of respect) some determining cause. She explains, "The feeling of respect is not a pathological but a *practical* feeling; it is not of empirical origin but is known a priori it 'is not the drive to morality, it is morality itself'".⁴⁰ This being of morality itself is central as the moral law requires the subject to find some identification with the law, not merely to find it as a determining ground, but for the subject to be of the nature such that there is an original predisposition to the good, as a Person, by which the law renders itself sensible to us. In regards to the possibility of a supersensible causality, i.e., freedom, Zupančič notes, "Kant finds this problem an 'insoluble problem of human reason', yet simultaneously a problem that is in some way always-already 'solved' in an ethical action."⁴¹ In other words, in the very essence of the problem as a problem, we find that we're already inculcated with a sense of respect for the moral law, irrevocably, as a matter of our being Persons. It is isn't merely the case that moral virtue is

³⁸ Alenka Zupančič, *Ethics of the Real: Kant and Lacan*, 141.

³⁹ Ibid.

⁴⁰ Ibid.

⁴¹ Ibid., 142.

not available to all—both structurally and empirically, the moral law is already found in the form of the Person who, through inner representations of the Law, find themselves free before the law to make decisions. In other words, within the faculty of desire, there is already a drive or a striving towards the moral law. Noticing the striking similarity between Kant and Lacan’s usages of the terms ‘drive’ and ‘desire’ she notes that, “[w]hen Lacan asserts that the drive ‘attains its satisfaction without attaining its goal’, this means precisely that the object of drive is not an object of representation.”⁴² As we’ll see shortly, this constitutes the Lacanian problem of the fantasy, wherein Kant gives us essentially a faculty capable of producing fantasmatic objects that are nonetheless efficacious, and must be presupposed as efficacious, in the very free activity of the human Person—Zupančič expands on this stating, “the object of the [Lacanian] drive is not an object supposed to provide some satisfaction to the subject, but this satisfaction itself: the object of drive is *satisfaction as object*” or, in other words, “[t]he object of the drive *coincides with the itinerary of the drive*, and is not something that this itinerary ‘intends’ to attain.”⁴³ The moral law within us thus strives, as noumenal object, for its establishment and efficacy in the world and yet, due to the propensity to evil within us, can never be fully actualized in our acts.

However, Zupančič is quick to point out that it is not merely “that respect is linked to a lack of representation” but also that “[w]hat gives rise to the feeling of respect is the absence of something constitutive of the subject of representation” so that “[t]he subject loses, so to speak, that which she never had: direct, immediate access to herself.”⁴⁴ Hence, it is not merely in reference to an absence of a representation that the will strives for but cannot be represented, but that such absence is *constitutive*, or even a condition possibility, of there being a subject at all —“In Lacanian terms, a little piece of the Real necessarily falls out in the constitution of the

⁴² Ibid.

⁴³ Ibid.

⁴⁴ Ibid., 143.

subject.”⁴⁵ Not only is this determinate lack the constitution of the subject “but the absence of this absence, of this lack which could provide a support for the subject of representation” such that “representation itself is founded on a certain lack or loss” and that “this situation is precisely that of a ‘lack that comes to lack’, a ‘lack that runs out’” which, as Zupančič reminds us, “is exactly Lacan’s definition of the cause of anxiety”.⁴⁶

Before venturing forth further towards the psychoanalytic implications of Kant’s theory of representation, it will be helpful to recall Kant’s analytic of the sublime in the *Third Critique*. In regards to understanding our feeling of the sublime, Kant offers the following definition stating that, “[t]he feeling of the inadequacy of our capacity for the attainment of an idea that is a law for us is respect.”⁴⁷ Here again, we see the theme of respect re-emerge, though as we will see shortly, Zupančič argues that something has changed from the respect that we encountered in the *Second Critique*. Nevertheless, an analysis of the inadequacy of the sublime will be helpful in further situation the way in which absence emerges as a category for the determination of the will. There are two modalities of the sublime, namely, the mathematical sublime and the dynamical sublime. Of the former, Kant states, “We call sublime that which is absolutely great.”⁴⁸ The determination of absolutely great requires, therefore, that for the sublime we not merely be able to attach some magnitude towards it, but that it encompasses magnitude as such and thus provides for our power of judgment a moment of reflective on its capacity to represent magnitude. He states, “...even if we have no interest at all in the object...still its mere magnitude, even if it is considered as formless, can bring with it a satisfaction that is universally communicable”.⁴⁹ Hence, though its universal communicability requires that it, in some way,

⁴⁵ Ibid.

⁴⁶ Ibid., 143-144.

⁴⁷ Immanuel Kant, *Critique of the Power of Judgment*, 140/5:257

⁴⁸ Ibid., 131/5:248.

⁴⁹ Ibid., 133/5:250.

engage the categories of the understanding, even if such categories subsequently fail to determine the degree to which they are engaged, it nevertheless signifies a relationship that is, subject *qua* subject, amenable to rational discourse—hence when Kant further defines the sublime as, “[t]hat is sublime which even to be able to think of demonstrates a faculty of the mind that surpasses every measure of the senses”⁵⁰ what should be fully appreciated here is that this is a capacity that *every* individual has, as a faculty of cognition, and should not be taken, as did Burke, as merely the capacity for some particular work of art to produce, but a properly transcendental capacity available to all people. This will allow Kant later to argue that it is in the sublime’s contrapurposiveness that we become aware of our freedom before the moral law and, hence, why it is a propaedeutic for the feeling of respect before Persons. To continue in the analytic, though, we must discuss the other modality of the sublime, namely, the dynamical.

According to Kant, “Nature considered in aesthetic judgment as a power that has no dominion over us is dynamically sublime.”⁵¹ The feeling corresponding to this power is fear, and Kant reminds us, “that which we strive to resist is an evil, and, if we find our capacity to be no match for it, an object of fear.”⁵² Of primary importance in our relation to objects of fear is the virtuous man’s relationship to God which though he “fears God without being afraid of him” since he recognizes in himself the attendance to his moral duty, nevertheless in regards to the outpouring of God’s wrath, “does not think of such a case as impossible in itself” and hence “recognizes God as fearful.”⁵³ Nevertheless, such a capacity of human faculties to recognize such sublimity is not merely a feature of our inadequacy—rather, such inadequacy is a positive

⁵⁰ Ibid., 134/5:251.

⁵¹ Ibid., 143/5:260.

⁵² Ibid., 144/5:261.

⁵³ Ibid.

condition that renders to us our freedom before the moral law. This will help contextualize the psychoanalytic discussion of the sublime which is to follow.

Zupančič analyzes the two moments of the sublime. She states, “The first is the moment of anxiety and of discomfiting fascination in the face of something incomparably larger and powerful than oneself... which the subject can escape only by transforming it into the second moment”.⁵⁴ In other words, the un-representability of the sublime requires the subject to transform the impending anxiety into a moment of reprieve wherein one realizes that the power and magnitude of the sublime is one’s own freedom before the law. She comments, “There are moments when something entrances us so much that we are ready to forget... everything, our well-being and all that is associated with it”⁵⁵ which is, in Lacanian terms, the kernel of the Real that simultaneously fascinates and repulses the subject. In Kant’s aesthetics, however, such an encounter is rendered in a merely disinterested fashion so that, in the analytic of the sublime, we are looking from the perspective of a “‘distinterested observer’ who is not overwhelmed and challenged by the same feeling of the sublime”.⁵⁶ What we have here, then, are not merely two moments, but two discourses regarding the nature of the sublime embodied in the same subject—one which looks at it from the perspective of the ego and the other from the superego. Zupančič relates this to Lacan’s work with narcissists to explain that narcissism is not “an ego closed in upon itself” but rather, to have self-reflective image, “I have to see or observe myself ‘from outside’, in a space that belongs to the Other.”⁵⁷ This is precisely what emerges in Lacan’s famous experiments regarding the ‘mirror stage’ wherein one’s self-image of oneself becomes a continuing unconscious discourse of one’s status in regards to the Other. Recall Kant’s religion

⁵⁴ Zupančič, *Ethics of the Real: Kant and Lacan*, 150.

⁵⁵ *Ibid.*, 152.

⁵⁶ *Ibid.*

⁵⁷ *Ibid.*, 153.

wherein humanity, as a cultural animality, can fall into the vice of vanity precisely by accounting for their moral worthiness from their image before others as opposed to their status before the moral law. Similarly, in the narcissist, we see the ongoing process of the sublime in its negative pleasure as Zupančič explains, “The ‘dialectic’ of narcissism revolves around the (possibility of) death of the subject.”⁵⁸ Hence, narcissism does not merely occupy a place of merely self-love “since this love cannot be entirely separated from hatred and destructive aggression directed against oneself”.⁵⁹ Thus, though the law inculcates us with a sense of our moral worth as Persons, it also has the potential to produce the excruciating demand of seeking sublime encounters of self-destructiveness to try and produce and to live up to this law. Faced with the trauma of the sublime, however, or of the constitutive anxiety which emerges from the lack of representation, the subject responds “by introducing a new distance, a kind of disinterestedness in the face of drastic concern”.⁶⁰ It is this distance, therefore, that defines the superego as “the subject’s having ‘withdrawn the psychical accent from his ego and having transposed it on to his superego” leading Zupančič to conclude, “[w]e can even say that the stronger the subject’s superego, the more this subject will be susceptible to the feeling of the sublime.”⁶¹ Thus it at the encounter with the sublime that we recognize “the superego as the place of *jouissance*”⁶² that is, of a pleasure beyond the pleasure principle wherein such pleasure is evaluated through a negative determination as the self-destructive power of the superego. Hence, for Zupančič, “devastating force ‘above me’ [which] easily evokes a devastating force ‘within me’” is the “feeling of the sublime [as it] develops through this metonymy.”⁶³ Hence, the discursive process of the superego

⁵⁸ Ibid.

⁵⁹ Ibid., 153.

⁶⁰ Ibid., 154.

⁶¹ Ibid.

⁶² Ibid., 156

⁶³ Ibid.

is one which, feeling its own inadequacy and lack, strives towards its own self-destruction.

Hence, Zupančič expands that it is in the beautiful and the sublime where, in the “purposive form without a purpose” we see the distinction between the beautiful and the sublime—“if the beautiful is characterized as the place where *Nature knows*, the sublime is the place where *Nature enjoys*” and where it is “precisely this *jouissance* of the Other, a *jouissance* that does not serve any (real or apparent) purpose” that constitutes the encounter with the sublime.⁶⁴

One last reading of the sublime may be suitable for our purposes. According to Joan Copjec, “Many have attempted to locate sexual difference in Kant’s texts, but what they in fact were looking for was sexual bias or sexual indifference.”⁶⁵ However, opposed to this critical reading of Kant, her reading is a positive reading where she claims “*Kant was the first to theorize, by means of a distinction, the difference that founds psychoanalysis’s division of all subjects into two mutually exclusive classes: male and female*”.⁶⁶ But male and female do not stand, for Copjec, for either biological or cultural entities (since, of course, this would instrumentalize the Person to either their animality or their enculturation) but rather, quoting Lacan, “two ways for the affair, the sexual relation, to misfire... There is the male way... and the female way.”⁶⁷ She locates this difference in the distinction that Kant makes between the dynamical sublime and the mathematical sublime. Of the former, she states that “[i]n Kant’s analysis, it is the dynamical antinomies (the “male side” of the formulas, in our reading) that appear in many ways secondary, a kind of *resolution* to a more fundamental *irresolvability*”.⁶⁸ This irresolvability translates to Lacan’s famous formula that “woman does not exist”.⁶⁹ Copjec

⁶⁴ Ibid., 157.

⁶⁵ Joan Copjec, *Read My Desire: Lacan against the Historicists*, 213.

⁶⁶ Ibid.

⁶⁷ Ibid.

⁶⁸ Ibid., 217.

⁶⁹ Ibid., 221.

explains in Lacan's words, "*In order to say 'it exists,' it is also necessary to be able to construct it, that is to say, to know how to find where this existence is*" to which Copjec supplements with Freud's explanation "who argued that in order to find an object, you must also be able to re-find it."⁷⁰ Hence, the coordinates of desire are such that one is led to a compulsion to repeat in order to find the singular encounter with the sublime, hence leading to pathology. But it is not true that the female and male sides of this failure to re-find the lost object of desire are symmetrical. Rather, arguing against contemporary nominalist accounts of gender, Copjec argues, "[w]e have... no problem in locating him, in proclaiming his existence."⁷¹ Despite this, however, "his ex-istence or being remains inaccessible nevertheless, since it escapes the conceptual or symbolic field in which his existence takes shape."⁷² This is because, as Copjec explains, in juxtaposition to the Aristotelian logic of causes which Kant takes to formulate the dynamical and mathematical antinomies, Lacan replaces the notion of cause with the notion of the phallic signifier.⁷³ This means that whereas woman cannot be found within the symbolic order as a matter of an existing thing, man can only be found within the symbolic order on the condition that what is signified never reaches any particular man—hence, similar to the form of negation that Kant demonstrates in his teleological antinomies where a world that is both completely explainable through mechanical laws and yet can also be explained as something which has some objects not explainable by reference to merely mechanical laws, leading to the postulate that there are free causes in the world (but not ones determined by the senses), a similar antinomy leads Lacanian analysis to conclude the impossibility of the sexual relation.

⁷⁰ Ibid.

⁷¹ Ibid., 227.

⁷² Ibid., 234.

⁷³ Ibid., 226-227.

In conclusion, we have discussed the concept of the Person as it emerges in the *Religion*, the relationship this has to concept of respect whose only proper object is such Person, and the nature of the sublime and its psychoanalytic implications for personhood. Whereas in Kant, the postulate of God is required for the possibility of the highest good in order to make amenable our ends in a world where, empirically, the propensity to evil necessarily frustrates all such ends, Lacanian psychoanalysis shows that the encounter in the sexual relation is a point of singular encounter with an object that engenders a feeling of respect and yet cannot be found within the symbolic order. Hence, the process of speaking and listening cannot restore to the analysand the lost object which they are looking for—similarly, the irrationality of our ends in the empirical world cannot be overcome through human culture. Instead, it requires the postulate of a God who has organized such lack to inspire in us a sense of our supersensible nature.

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